

Worry Time Planner

A tool to manage anxious thoughts.



Worrying can feel like an unstoppable tide, pulling you away from the present moment and draining your energy. While occasional worry is a normal human experience, excessive or persistent worry can significantly impact your well-being, productivity, and overall happiness. This planner is designed to help you take control of your worry by establishing a dedicated 'worry time,' a strategy that allows you to acknowledge and process your concerns in a controlled environment, rather than letting them disrupt your entire day.

Why a Worry Time Planner?

- **Containment:** By allocating a specific time and place for worry, you prevent it from spilling into other areas of your life.
- **Reduced Frequency:** Over time, your brain learns to associate worry with a designated period, potentially reducing the spontaneous onset of anxious thoughts.
- **Problem-Solving Focus:** Worry time can be used not just for rumination, but for actively brainstorming solutions to your concerns.
- **Mindfulness Practice:** Successfully engaging in worry time can be a form of mindfulness, helping you observe your thoughts without immediate judgment or reaction.
- **Improved Sleep:** By setting aside worries during the day, you can reduce the likelihood of them keeping you awake at night.

How to Use Your Worry Time Planner

1. Schedule Your Worry Time:

- **Choose a consistent time:** Select a daily slot, ideally early in the evening but *not* right before bed. This allows you to process worries without them interfering with sleep.
- **Duration:** Start with 15-30 minutes. You can adjust this as you get more comfortable.
- **Location:** Pick a specific, quiet place where you won't be interrupted. Avoid doing this in your bedroom or while multitasking.

2. During Worry Time:

- **Write it Down:** Keep a notebook or use a digital document. When a worry arises *outside* your scheduled time, jot it down and tell yourself you'll address it during your worry time. This is key to delaying the worry.
- **Focus on Concerns:** During your scheduled worry time, take out your list. Read each worry and consider:
 - Is this something I can do something about?
 - If yes: Brainstorm concrete steps and write them down. Schedule them for later.
 - If no: Acknowledge that you cannot change it right now. Practice letting go or acceptance. You might find it helpful to write "Can't do anything about this now" next to it.
- **Avoid Ruminating:** The goal is to process, not to get stuck in a loop. If you find yourself endlessly repeating the same anxious thought, gently redirect yourself to the next item on your list or to your problem-solving questions.

Sample Worry Log

Date	Time Scheduled	Worry	Actionable?	Next Steps/Notes

Tips for Success

- **Be Patient:** This is a skill that takes practice. Don't get discouraged if it doesn't feel effective immediately.

- **Be Realistic:** You won't eliminate worry entirely, but you can manage its impact.
- **Be Kind to Yourself:** If you miss a worry time session or find yourself worrying outside of it, acknowledge it without self-criticism and try again the next day.
- **Consider Professional Help:** If worry is significantly impacting your life and you're struggling to manage it, consider speaking with a therapist or counsellor. They can offer additional strategies and support.

Next Steps

1. **Identify a daily time and place** for your worry sessions.
2. **Commit to jotting down worries** that arise throughout the day, rather than engaging with them immediately.
3. **Begin using your planner** for your scheduled worry time, focusing on processing and problem-solving.
4. **Review and adjust** your approach as needed after a week or two.